Friday, January 20

Two days ago the Israeli Supreme Court voted by a majority of 10 to 1 that Aryeh Deri—the leader of the Shas party and Netanyahu's main ally, whom he appointed interior minister —could not serve due to two previous sentences for tax fraud and his own promise, in 2022, not to seek further public office in order to avoid a felony sentence. Instead he scrambled into a place in the present coalition. We do not know yet how Netanyahu will react to the Supreme Court's decision.

In many ways the new Israeli coalition is similar to other ultra-right governments in Hungary, Poland, Italy, and Turkey, and to the political program of the ultra-right-wing Republicans in the US (Trumpists). But it also has its specific characteristics. Thus, for example, in Europe, this kind of government is in the hands of a wealthy upper crust, supported by established religion, the army, and a majority of bamboozled "white trash" (intensely nationalist, xenophobic, and, more often than not, antisemitic). In the case of Trumpists, it is not supported by people of color. In Israel, however, Deri's party is essentially a party belonging to people of color, whose families immigrated in the 1950s from North Africa and the Middle East, who lived for years in dilapidated transit camps and occupied the lowest strata of the labor market. These Sephardim (historically, Jews coming from Spain) were looked down upon by the Ashkenazim (Jews coming from Germany, and mainly from Eastern Europe).

I arrived in Israel from France, having earlier fled from Prague in 1939. It didn't help my parents. I was hidden, they were caught and murdered. The Israeli village in which my uncles lived and where I arrived in June 1948 was populated by German-speaking Czech Jews, the most Ashkenazi Ashkenazim you could imagine: no religion, little Hebrew, and all the habits of yesteryear, even as they were putting down new roots. Israel was not a refuge, it was a country that one called home, or "Heimat" if that was easier for you. But, unfortunately, racism existed in the new Heimat.